

Global traditional Medicine Policy

- The world is awakening towards the benefits of TM
- The global policy on traditional medicine led by the WHO (which will run from 2025 to 2034) focuses on:
 - ✓ Integrating traditional medicine into modern healthcare.
 - ✓ Ensuring safety, quality, and effectiveness through research and regulation.
 - ✓ Respecting cultural heritage, while promoting innovation and global collaboration.
 - ✓ Supporting universal health coverage and equitable access.

How Countries Approach TM

- **Integrated Systems:** (e.g., China, India, South Korea, Vietnam) TM is fully integrated into the national healthcare system,
 - with licensed practitioners, public hospitals, and insurance coverage.
- **Regulated Products/Professionals:** (e.g., Canada, EU, Australia) Herbal medicines are regulated as "Natural Health Products" or "Traditional Herbal Medicinal Products,"
 - with varying levels of practitioner regulation.
- **Tolerated but Not Recognized:** TM is widely practiced but lacks formal recognition, regulation, or integration into the formal health system.
- **Prohibited:** Rare, but some practices may be illegal.
- **Ethiopia?**

Traditional Medicine Policy of Ethiopia

Key Policy Objectives & Strategic Directions

- Register and license TM products and practitioners.
- Strengthen quality, safety, and efficacy through research, regulation, and standardization of traditional medicine products and practices.
- Integrate traditional medicine into the national health system
- Preserve, document, and protect indigenous knowledge including plant resources; address intellectual property and conservation issues.
- Capacity building: training practitioners, regulatory officers, developing infrastructure (labs, regulatory tools) for implementation

Traditional Medicine Policy of Ethiopia: key points

- 1993 Health, Drug, and Science & Technology Policy includes traditional medicine as one of eight priorities; encourages research, gradual integration, regulation and registration of practitioners.
- **Proclamation No. 1112/2019** (Food & Drug Authority) provides regulation over medicine, including herbal medicines.
- Licensing of traditional healers typically falls under **Woreda (local) or Regional Health Bureaus**
- **Traditional Medicine Research and Roadmap (2019)** aimed at policy revision, strengthening control mechanisms, documentation and preservation of indigenous knowledge, and capacity building among practitioners.

Implementation: Status, Progress & Gaps

- Research directorate (TMMRD in the Ethiopian Public Health Institute) has done laboratory testing for some traditional remedies; some are ready for field assessment.
- There have been validation workshops for policy, strategy, and proclamations.
- However, key gaps remain:
 - No distinct, standalone legal framework for herbal medicine (many policy & regulation functions remain weak).
 - Weak enforcement of existing regulations.
 - Lack of registered herbal medicine manufacturing firms, and lack of pharmacovigilance systems

Sammary: The Rationale for Regulation

- **Public Health & Safety:**

- Ensure quality, safety, and efficacy of TM products and practices.
- Protect patients from adulterated products, incorrect dosage, and harmful practices.

- **Access to Healthcare:**

- TM is often the first and most accessible line of treatment, especially in rural and underserved areas.
- Policy can help integrate TM into primary healthcare systems.

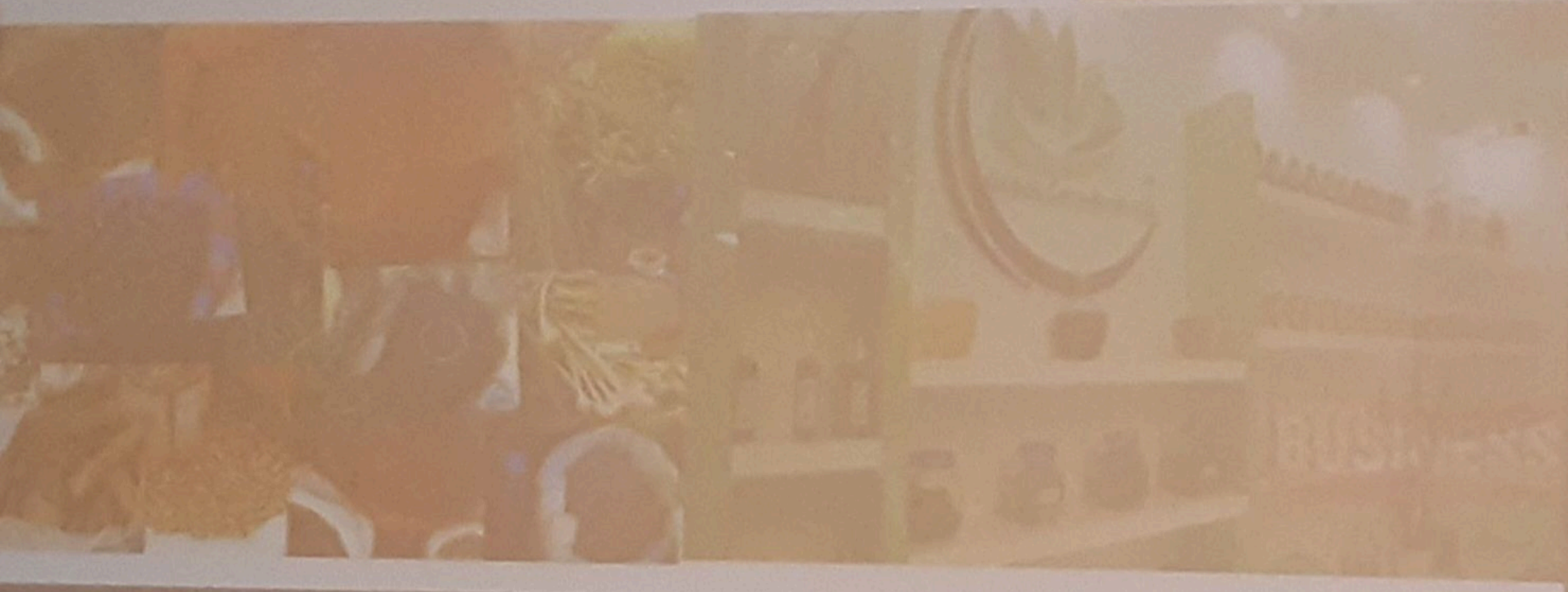
- **Preservation & Sustainability:**

- Protect indigenous knowledge from biopiracy and misappropriation.
- Promote sustainable cultivation of medicinal plants.

- **Economic Development:**

- Create a formalized industry, generating jobs and income for practitioners, farmers, and researchers.

Ethiopian Traditional Medicine



Ethiopian Traditional Medicine

- Ethiopia has a rich tradition of using herbal, spiritual, and other traditional healing practices; over 80% of the population rely on traditional medicine, especially in rural areas.
- country's flora is diverse: about 6,500–7,000 species of higher plants; 12% of those are endemic; more than 95% of traditional medicine preparations are plant-based.
- Traditional medicine (TM) is not just used for healing physical ailments; it often intersects with spiritual, social, mental, and community wellbeing

Historical Foundations

- **Antiquity:**

Evidence from Aksumite inscriptions, medieval manuscripts, and oral traditions.

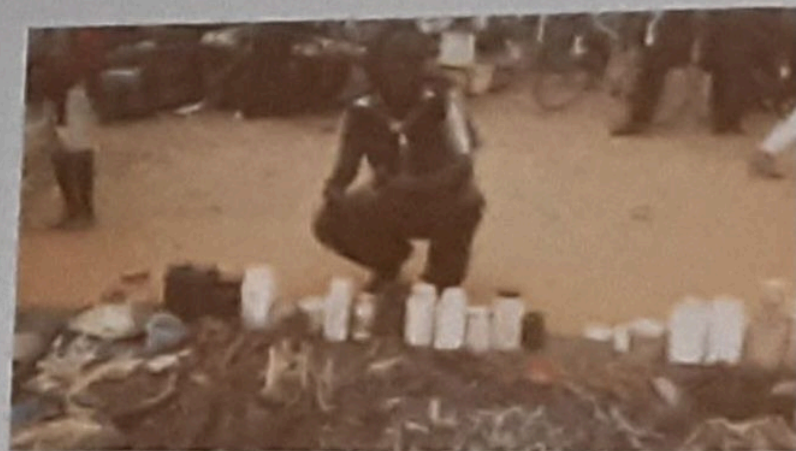
- **Influences:**

- Cushitic and Omotic healing cosmologies
- Christian (Orthodox) liturgical healing traditions
- Islamic Unani and Arabic medical scholarship



Diverse Therapeutic Modalities

1. **Herbal Medicine:** The most widespread form. Utilizes plants, roots, leaves, and seeds prepared as decoctions, powders, poultices, or fumes.
2. **Spiritual Healing:** Addresses ailments believed to have supernatural causes. Involves rituals, prayers, use of holy water, and amulets led by specific healers.
3. **Physical Therapies:**
 - **Bone Setting (Wogesha):** Manual manipulation and herbal splints for fractures.
 - **Massage:** For pain relief and musculoskeletal issues.
 - **Scarification/Cauterization:** Making small cuts or applying heat to specific points to release "bad blood" or treat internal pain.



The Keepers of Knowledge (practitioners)

- **Traditional Healers:** A diverse group with specialized roles:

- *Wogasha*: Bone setter.
- *Bahel hakim*: Herbalist.
- *Debtera*: Lay scholar in the Orthodox Church who may act as a scribe, healer, and diviner.

- **Religious Leaders:**

- **Priests (*Kes*):** Provide spiritual healing, holy water, and prayers.
- **Sheikhs:** Islamic leaders who may use prayers from the Qur'an and traditional remedies.

- **Birth Attendants:** Elderly women with expertise in prenatal care, delivery, and postnatal care using traditional methods.

Principles of Ethiopian TM

1. Etiological Principles (The Causes of Illness)

- This principle defines *why* people get sick. Illness is attributed to multiple, often interconnected, causes:
- **Natural/Physical Causes:**
 - **Imbalance in the Body:** Similar to humoral concepts in other traditions, there is a notion of balance between "hot" and "cold" states within the body. A "hot" illness (like fever, rash) requires a "cold" remedy, and vice-versa.
 - **Environmental Factors:** Exposure to cold, heat, wind, or poor diet can disrupt the body's natural state.
 - **Trauma:** Physical injuries from accidents or fights.

- **Supernatural/Spiritual Causes:**

- **Evil Eye (Buda):** This is a central concept. Illness or misfortune can be caused by a glance from a person (often unintentionally) endowed with a powerful "evil eye."
- **Spirit Possession (Zar):** A class of spirits (*Zar*) can possess an individual, causing physical or mental illness. The spirit must be appeased, not exorcised, through specific rituals.
- **Ancestral Spirits or Curses:** Illness may be a punishment from displeased ancestral spirits or the result of a curse placed by another person.
- **Sin or Moral Transgression:** Sickness can be seen as a consequence of violating social, moral, or religious laws.

2. Diagnostic Principles (Identifying the Cause)

- Diagnosis is a holistic process aimed at identifying which of the above causes is at play.
- **Observation & Physical Examination:** Healers observe the patient's appearance, eyes, tongue, and skin. Palpation and pulse reading are also common.
- **Patient History:** Detailed questioning about diet, lifestyle, social conflicts, and dreams.
- **Spiritual Divination:** For suspected supernatural causes, healers use various methods:
 - Interpretation of Dreams
 - Reading Patterns in Coffee Grounds (Tire Buna)
 - Using Sacred Texts or Verses (e.g., by a Debtera)

3. Therapeutic Principles (The Approach to Healing)

- Treatment is tailored to the diagnosed cause, not just the symptom.
- **The Principle of Opposition (Counteracting):** Used for natural imbalances. A "hot" disease is treated with a "cold" plant, and vice-versa.
- **The Principle of Symbolism and Spiritual Intervention:** Used for spiritual ailments.
 - **Rituals and Sacrifices:** To appease spirits (Zar ceremonies) or ancestral spirits.
 - **Prayers and Holy Water (Tsebel):** To invoke divine intervention for healing and protection, especially in the Ethiopian Orthodox tradition.
 - **Amulets and Talismans:** Worn to ward off the evil eye or harmful spirits.

- **The Principle of Purification:**

- **Bloodletting (Kenefit):** To remove "bad" or "polluted" blood from the body and restore balance.
- **Purging and Emetics:** To cleanse the body from within.

- **The Principle of Restoration:**

- **Bone Setting (Wogesha):** To restore physical structure and function.
- **Nutritional Therapy:** Using specific foods to restore strength and balance.

4. Pharmacological Principles (The Use of Remedies)

- The use of medicinal plants is guided by deep, empirical knowledge.
- **The Doctrine of Signatures:** The physical characteristics of a plant (shape, color, smell) can indicate its therapeutic use.
- **Energetic Qualities:** Plants are classified by their inherent "hot" or "cold" properties, which determine their use.
- **Synergy and Preparation:** Remedies are often complex mixtures of multiple plants, prepared in specific ways (decoctions, powders, poultices, fumigation) to enhance efficacy or reduce toxicity.

Why Ethiopians Rely on TM

- **High Utilization:** An estimated **80% of the Ethiopian population** relies on TM for their primary healthcare needs.
- **Key Drivers:**
 - **Accessibility & Affordability:** Healers and remedies are often more available and less expensive than modern clinics, especially in rural areas.
 - **Cultural Trust & Acceptance:** TM aligns with local beliefs and worldviews; healers are respected community figures.
 - **Preference in Rural Areas:** In many underserved regions, TM is the only readily available form of healthcare.